

Plow

This **ICON OF AGRICULTURE** is still a top crop tool for farmers

The plow is a farming tool used to prepare the earth for the seed-sowing season. Plowing has saved farmers time and toil in the fields, and transformed food production.

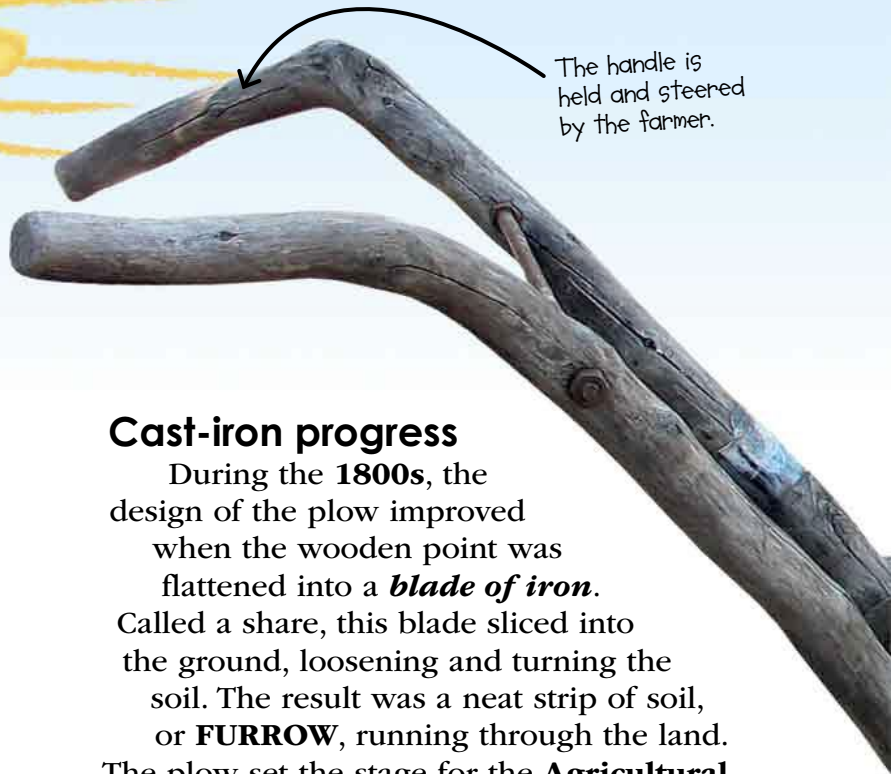
Did you know?

Camels and llamas have been used to pull plows in regions where there were too few horses and oxen.



Ancient ards

Plowing has been an integral part of the **FARMING CALENDAR** since ancient times. Turning the earth in the fall prepares the ground for seed sowing in the spring. Around **5000 BCE**, early civilizations broke the ground with an **antler or branch** to cultivate crops. This developed into a pointed wooden plow called an **ARD**. The ancient Egyptians attached the ard to a beam harnessed to two oxen and got to work plowing the Nile valley.



The handle is held and steered by the farmer.

Cast-iron progress

During the **1800s**, the design of the plow improved when the wooden point was flattened into a **blade of iron**. Called a share, this blade sliced into the ground, loosening and turning the soil. The result was a neat strip of soil, or **FURROW**, running through the land. The plow set the stage for the **Agricultural Revolution**, reducing the effort required to produce large quantities of crops. Metal blades are still used to cut furrows today.

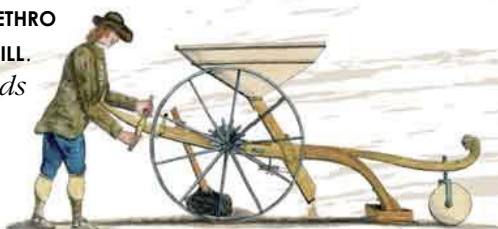
By the way...

Medieval plows were so heavy that it was not uncommon for eight oxen to pull a single machine.

Share blade cuts and loosens soil.

It paved the way for...

In 1700, Englishman **JETHRO TULL** invented the **SEED DRILL**. This device dropped seeds down a chute into a furrow in organized rows called drills.



A **HORSE-DRAWN REAPER** was patented in 1834.

CYRUS McCORMICK's mechanism made cutting and gathering crops less strenuous.

